EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Should a Jew Withdraw from the World?

Given Monday 24 November 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 10:4-6

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 10 (How a Person Should Conduct Himself in This World), Chapters 4 to 6: abstinence, eating and drinking, and intimacy

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 24 November 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: The Balanced Life

Last week Saadia laid down the theme of the tenth essay. The nature of the world and of human beings is multiplicity. Some people single out one thing and pursue it to the exclusion of everything else, which is never the right way. "The right way to conduct one's life is always with balance," just as Hakadosh Baruch Hu created the world with many different things.

The Rabbi stressed that this is "not just about *midot*." It applies to our character, and also to our ambitions and goals in life. He added an observation: "That's where *kana'ut*, zealousness, comes from, by the way." Zealotry is focusing on one thing to the exclusion of others, "and very often people who focus on one thing to the exclusion of other things, they themselves have issues with that problem, which is why they become so zealous about it."

Saadia also set out the three faculties, desire, emotion and cognition, and taught that the wise person lives with cognition in control of the other two. And he read Shlomo HaMelech's *hevel* as referring to wisdom, pleasure or work taken to an extreme alone.

The thirteen paths

At the start of Chapter 4 Saadia listed the thirteen things he will examine:

1. Abstinence (*perishut*)
2. Eating and drinking
3. Intimacy
4. Passion
5. Children
6. Building up the world (*yishuv*)
7. Long life
8. Money
9. Power and status
10. Revenge, righting every wrong

11. Work
12. Wisdom
13. Rest

The aim tonight: Chapters 4 to 7. In the event the class reached the end of Chapter 6.

Chapter 4: Abstinence (*Perishut*)

The hermits

Perishut means abstinence or asceticism. "All the Rishonim talked about this. It seemed to have been a common thing in the olden days, certainly amongst other religions and even amongst Jews." The earliest instance the Rabbi found was the **Desert Fathers**, early Christian hermits and ascetics who lived mainly in Egypt from around the third century. The Rambam, Rabbeinu Bachya ibn Pakuda in Chovot HaLevavot, and others all discuss people who cut themselves off and went to live as hermits.

Their argument

The Rabbi warned: "It's very depressing, this paragraph, I'm just warning you."

> **ראו אנשים כי אשר ראוי שיתנהג בו האדם בעולם הזה הפרישות וההליכה על ההרים ולבכות ולספוד ולהתאבל על העולם הזה**

Some people hold that a person should withdraw to the mountains and weep, lament and mourn over this world. Their reasons:

- **This world comes to an end.** It turns against its inhabitants and does not endure. Whenever a person rejoices in calm and tranquility, it turns on him and his joy becomes mourning. His greatness becomes his downfall, and his success comes only with great toil. **עשיר ישכב ולא יאסף, עיניו פקח ואיננו**: the rich man lies down and it is gone.
- **Every effort backfires.** Try to be wise and you end up foolish; try to be pure and you are sullied; try to be healthy and illness shuts you in; try to speak well and your tongue trips you. **אם אצדק פי ירשיעני**.
- **No one knows what tomorrow brings:** illness, injury, bereavement, worry and loss. **אל תתהלל ביום מחר כי לא תדע מה ילד יום**.
- **Whatever you lean on gives way.** "What a beautiful pasuk," said the Rabbi: **אשר יקוט כסלו ובית עכביש מבטחו**. Whatever we trust, our wealth, our status, our job, our house, is a spider's web. **ישען על ביתו ולא יעמוד**.
- **The world is full of falsehood.** How many mighty people has Hashem brought down, **אשתוללו אבירי לב**, and how many of the great has He humbled, **לחלל גאון כל צבי להקל כל נכבדי ארץ**.
- **Kindness is repaid with harm.** We open our eyes in the morning looking for light, and the world goes dark. **כי טוב קויתי ויבא רע**.
- **And above all, our sins,** the reckoning and the suffering, and the distance between us and Hashem, until it seems He is like a lion tearing at us, **כשחל תצודני**, and **הנה יום ה' בא אכזרי ועברה וחרון אף**.

Their conclusion:

> **צריך למאוס בעולם הזה, ולא יבנה בית ולא יטע, ולא יקח אשה ולא יוליד**

Reject this world. Don't build a house, don't plant, don't marry, don't have children. "How many times do we hear this in this generation now? I don't want to bring children into this world." And don't live among people

who do these things, lest they influence you. Instead go and be alone in the mountains, eat whatever plants you find, until you die in worry and mourning.

"Basically everything is fleeting in this life. Because everything is fleeting, it's not worth investing."

Saadia: mostly true, but they erred

והסתכלתי במה שאמרה האומה הזאת ומצאתי ברובם אמת, אך טעו בעזיבת הישוב ובני אדם

"I think the majority of what this group say is true." The Rabbi noted that Saadia said this before, in the discussion of reward and punishment in this world: most of this world is pain and difficulty. "Some people can sympathize with that, some people less."

Their mistake was in what they did with it:

1. **They abandoned food, clothing and shelter,** which no one can live without.
2. **They abandoned marriage.** If not having children were good, then everyone should do it, **עד שיבטל מין המדברים**, until the human race ended. With it would end wisdom, Torah, the Day of Judgment and the settled world. Hashem created the world, so that cannot be right. The Rabbi: "That's the famous argument against the Christian doctrine of priests not getting married." If it is the ideal, then everyone should aspire to it, and there would be no future for humanity.
3. **They put themselves in physical danger,** among wild animals, lions and snakes, heat and cold.
4. **They damaged their minds.** Without proper food, warmth and company, nature deteriorates and the mind goes, until they need to come back to town to be healed, and it does not always help.
5. **They lost their humanity.** Some returned and were so shocked by ordinary life that they thought people deserved to die, and some even allowed themselves to shed blood. Others became like animals: **בת עמי לאכזר כיענים במדבר**, like ostriches in the desert, and **בערוץ נחלים לשכון, חורי עפר וכפים... בין שיחים ינהקו**.

When is *perishut* good?

אבל הפרישות טובה לאדם כשיתנהג בה במקומה, והוא כי הזדמן לו המאכל והמשתה האסור והמשגל האסור והממון האסור

Abstinence is good in its place: when forbidden food, forbidden drink, a forbidden relationship or forbidden money comes his way. "You have an opportunity to steal, you have an opportunity to be deceitful... that's the time you do *perishut*." Then he should use this trait to distance himself from all of it.

What exactly is Saadia's view?

The Rabbi pointed out a tension. On one hand Saadia agrees that the ascetics' picture of the world is largely true. On the other, his practical conclusion is that one uses *perishut* only for what is forbidden. "It doesn't seem like Saadia's of the view that it's good to fast... It doesn't seem that kind of asceticism is one which he endorses." Would he endorse someone fasting from permitted food? "I don't think so. I'm not sure." What is clear is that abstaining from the forbidden is something everyone agrees on.

Other Rishonim on Abstinence

Rabbeinu Bachya: abstain in your heart

In Chovot HaLevavot, Rabbeinu Bachya describes three groups who practise *perishut*:

Group	What they do	Verdict
1	Want to be like angels: leave society, live in the mountains and eat vegetation	Exactly Saadia's hermits. Not the Torah way
2	Live among people but reject everything physical: fast, deny all pleasures	Better than the first, but also not correct
3	Separate from the world **in their hearts**	The correct way

והוא שפרשו מן העולם בלבבותם ומצפונם, וישתתפו עם אנשי העולם בנראה מגופיהם בישוב העולם... ונפשם מואסות בעולם ובהונו ונכספות לעולם הבא

They withdraw inwardly but join other people outwardly in building the world, ploughing and sowing and trading. They understand what a person's situation in this world is, his sojourn here and his exposure to pain, and their souls long for the World to Come. "Be normal. Live amongst people, have relationships with people, go out, talk, chat. I'm there, I'm with you, I'm present." But in your mind you know this is not the end. Rabbeinu Bachya endorses *perishut*, "but only mentally, only in your mind."

The Rambam: abstinence as medicine

The class learned this in Shemonah Perakim a couple of years ago:

אבל מה שעשו אותם החסידים בקצת הזמנים... הם גם כן מנהגות החולים על דרך הרפואה, בצום וקום בלילות והנחת תענוגי הגופות... ולבוש הצמר והשער ושכונת ההרים והתבודד במדברות, לא עשו דבר מזה אלא על דרך רפואה

The Rambam does not deny that there were pious people who, for periods, fasted, rose at night, gave up meat and wine, and even went to the mountains. But they did it as **medicine**, to cure a bad trait. If someone feels he has become too preoccupied with food, he might fast by day for forty days to wean himself off it. "That *perishut* is good *perishut*."

For the Rambam, "there is no independent value to *perishut*." Its only value is in training the character back to the golden mean: when you have gone too far one way, you go towards the other extreme for a time. "Extreme is only good if you're trying to balance yourself out, but never in and of itself."

The Kuzari: the Torah did not bring us asceticism

Rabbi Yehudah HaLevi, the Chaver, says it unequivocally:

תורת משה לא הביאתנו בפרישות, אך בדרך השוה תרצה, ולתת לכל כח מכחות הנפש והגוף חלקו בצדק מבלי רבות כח אחד על חברו

The Torah wants the balanced path, giving every faculty of soul and body its rightful share, without one overwhelming another. One who gives too much to desire falls short in thought, and the reverse. Frequent fasting is no service for someone whose desires and strength are already weak. Look after your body. Don't treat poverty as a virtue: earn a living that still lets you study.

The key line:

ואין הכנעתך בימי התענית יותר קרובה אל האלוהים משמחתך בימי השבתות והמועדים

Your submission on fast days is no closer to God than your joy on Shabbat and Yom Tov, when your joy is a complete service. "Have a good time, enjoy, look after your body, look after yourself. That's the correct

way."

The Nazir

The Rabbi recalled a point discussed in the past: at the end of his term the Nazir brings a sin offering. He may need to separate himself for a time, "fine, great," but the offering teaches that this is not the right way to live permanently.

The common thread

Thinker	When *perishut* is right
Saadia	When something **forbidden** is in front of you
The Rambam	As **therapy**, for a limited time, to bring yourself back to balance
Rabbeinu Bachya	**In your mind**: know this world is temporary, while living a normal life among people
The Kuzari	The Torah does not ask for it. Joy on Shabbat and Yom Tov is the greater service

Someone asked what *perishut* means. Abstinence; it is the noun, and *perishuyot* is its plural.

Chapter 5: Eating and Drinking

The second extreme: people who think life is about good food and good drink. "Eat and drink, for tomorrow we will die."

Their argument

ראו קצת בני אדם כי הראוי שיתנהג בו האדם שער אכילה ושתיה

- **Food sustains body and soul,** it is very pleasant, and it is what makes bodies grow and multiply.
- **Fast one day and you weaken:** your sight, hearing, thought, memory and reasoning fade. Eat, and they all return. Sometimes a person who is famished **יכפור באלוהיו**, denies his God, and cannot understand what he is praying. (The Rabbi: "For Saadia, the only time he didn't concentrate in prayer seems to be when he's fasting.")
- **All settlement follows food.** People build only where there are fields and water. Kings' taxes and soldiers' wars are about food. Hence the saying, "this is my bread."
- **The Torah promises food to the righteous: ועבדתם את ה' אלקיכם וברך את לחמך ואת מימיך**, and **ונתנה הארץ פריה ואכלתם לשבע**.
- **Every occasion needs food:** an engagement, a wedding, a birth, a brit milah, a festival, a dedication. The Rabbi: "Whenever you go to an event, there has to be food there." Kiddush on Friday night, Kiddush on Shabbat, breakfast in the morning.
- **Friendship runs on it.** "Can I offer you a cup of tea?" You cannot just sit and talk without something to eat or drink.
- **Wine** looks lovely, smells good and tastes sweet. It cheers the anxious, makes the miser generous and the faint-hearted brave. **ויין ישמח לבב אנוש להצהיל פנים משמן**.

So, they say, life should be the pursuit of the best food: a better piece of meat, a better meal, a more expensive wine. The Rabbi told a true story of someone who drank a bottle of wine costing many

thousands, and remarked that his urine would now be very expensive.

Saadia: mostly mistaken

והתבוננתי במאמרם זה ומצאתי רובו טעות, כי הם מביטים לטובותיו ולא מביטים לרעותיו

They see the good and ignore the harm:

- **The body:** too much food causes indigestion, makes the body and limbs heavy and the head and eyes dull, and brings on faintness. "You know when you've had too much at a dinner... you can't study, you can't do things." It changes a person's disposition.
- **Money:** the appetite drives him to chase money to buy more food.
- **Never full:** he forgets what satiety is and becomes like dogs, **והכלבים עזי נפש לא ידעו שבעה**.
- **Losing the taste:** like fire, which consumes whatever comes to it without feeling, **ויהי העם כמאכלת אש**. When you eat at the right time you enjoy it; when you eat constantly "you lose the sensitivity to good food."
- **Like death and Sheol,** which never say "enough": **אשר הרחיב כשאול נפשו והוא כמות ולא ישבע**, and like the four things that are never sated in Mishlei, Sheol, the barren womb, the earth that is never full of water, and fire.
- **Stinginess:** he begrudges anyone who eats from his food, and if he gives, it is without a full heart: **אכול ושתה יאמר לך ולבו בל עמך**.
- **Social disgrace:** kings, great people and the wise will not sit with him. He eats fast, jumps on the best piece, is first to the meal and last to leave, with his eyes on the next course. **ושמת שכין בלעך אם בעל נפש אתה**.
- **Gluttony's excesses:** the Rabbi noted that among the Romans people would make themselves vomit in order to eat more. The glutton becomes a funnel, pouring in at the top and out at the bottom. **כי כל שלחנות מלאו קיא צואה בלי מקום**.
- **Forgetting Hashem: כמרעיתם וישבעו, שבעו וירם לבם, על כן שכחוני**.
- **The harm of wine:** it overpowers the intellect, **לץ היין הומה שכר וכל שגה בו לא יחכם**. It weakens the sinews and damages the liver ("that we know today, alcohol ruins the liver"), and brings illnesses of the blood and the bowels. It is **למי אוי למי אבוי**. It loosens every restraint and leads to every disgrace, and it creeps through the body slowly, **אחריתו כנחש ישך**. Killing, beatings, prison and punishment come through it, and all manner of fraud and trickery.
- **Theft:** one who gets used to feasting will take it wherever he can find it: **כי לחמו לחם רשע ויין חמסים ישתו**.

When are food and drink good?

הן טובים לאדם לקחת מהם כדי קיום גופו

Take what you need to sustain your body. **צדיק אוכל לשובע נפשו**. When your intellect sees there is a place for it, send out the desire; when there is no need, hold it back.

The Rabbi on eating

"This was quite radical for their times." In the old days, the fatter you were, the wealthier you were seen to be, and there was no concept of a diet. Two hundred years later the Rambam wrote in Hilchot Deot that most illnesses come from overeating. "And how true is that nowadays." Once a person is mindful of what goes into his mouth, "it completely changes their life."

When should a person eat? When he is hungry, because he needs it. "There's no such concept as eating and drinking for stress." Nor because "I just desire this cake and this pudding." He recommended reading the Rambam's Hilchot Deot Chapter 4: "you read that and you end up only eating and drinking what you need for a few days, until you forget it."

Someone asked whether that means eating only when starving. "No, not starving." The Rambam says to stop at around two-thirds or three-quarters of your appetite. "Don't eat until you struggle to get up and you have to loosen your belt." Stop when you feel, "I'm not hungry anymore. Of course I can eat more. There's some beautiful meat here... But I'm full up now." This idea, he said, is echoed by essentially all the Rishonim: eat and drink **קיום נפשו**, what you need to live the best life.

Chapter 6: Intimacy

The third extreme: people who think marital relations should be preferred over all the world's pleasures.

Their argument

- It is the greatest pleasure there is. Everything else has a substitute; this has none.
- It gladdens and strengthens the soul, lightens a heavy spirit, calms anger, and relieves the black bile called melancholia.
- Above all, it is the cause of human existence, and the closest bond of affection between people.
- If it were shameful, Hashem would have kept it from His prophets. Yet Yaakov said, **הבה את אשתי ואבואה אליה**, without embarrassment (from that week's parasha), and Yeshayahu said, **ואקרב אל הנביאה**, without shame.

Saadia: they are wrong

וחקרתי דברים האלה ומצאתים בטלים, כי הניחו הנזק ועוצם העון

They forgot the harm and the gravity of the sin:

- **Physical harm,** as the medicine of the time held: it weakens the eyes (a common belief then, which the Rambam and even the Shulchan Aruch quote; "I don't think it's true nowadays," said the Rabbi), saps strength and appetite, brings illness and hastens old age. **אל תתן לנשים חילך**.
- **Confusion of mind: זנות ויין ותירוש יקח לב**. One whose heart is fixed on it cannot rest until he has it, and as soon as he has it he wants more, **כלם מנאפים כמו תנור בערה מאפה**.
- **Spiritual stain:** one who is sensitive would feel his garments are soiled, even if he washed all his days, **אם התרחצתי במו שלג... אז בשחת תטבלני ותעבוני שלמותי**.
- **Lasting shame:** a sin like adultery stays with a person to the end of his days. **נגע וקלון ימצא וחרפתו לא תמחה**.
- **Losing all sense of being seen:** he imagines everyone is blind and deaf, and does shameful things in the open.
- **His home becomes a meeting place for the wrong people, ובית זונה יתגודדו**.
- **Measure for measure:** he brings confusion of lineage, and may find it repaid in his own home, **תטחן לאחר אשתי**.

When is this desire good?

ואין התאוה הזאת טובה לאדם כי אם בזרע

Saadia says its purpose is children, **ואתם פרו ורבו**, and it should be sent out with understanding when it is needed for that.

The Rabbi thought Saadia was being brief here. Halachically marital relations are encouraged, and even obligatory, when a wife is pregnant or past childbearing age. The **Ramban** writes in several places that the bond has value when it creates affection and love and strengthens the relationship. "I don't think Saadia means only to have children and nothing else. That I don't think makes sense at all. That goes against everything which we know in all the Gemara and all the Rishonim." His point is that this too is an extreme to avoid.

Summary

1. **Zealotry** is focusing on one thing to the exclusion of all else, and often comes from a person's own struggle with that very thing.
2. **Abstinence:** the ascetics' picture of a painful, fleeting world is mostly true, but withdrawing, not marrying and living in the wild is wrong. If everyone did it, humanity and Torah would end. Saadia uses *perishut* for the forbidden; the Rambam as temporary therapy; Rabbeinu Bachya in the heart while living among people; the Kuzari says joy on Shabbat and Yom Tov is the greater service.
3. **Eating and drinking:** their defenders see only the good. Overeating harms body, character, friendships and faith, and wine leads to every kind of wrong. Eat what sustains you, and stop before you are full.
4. **Intimacy:** pursued as the goal of life it harms body, mind and soul. Saadia ties it to children; the Rabbi added, with the Ramban, that its value in building love is also fully recognised.

Coming Up

- **Next week, same time:** Chapter 7 (passion) and the chapters that follow. The Rabbi hopes to finish the tenth essay before the winter holidays and begin a new sefer next year.
- **Tomorrow night (Tuesday):** the Rambam shiur continues.

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